

Chapter 40-6

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Liang Shi arrived at the restaurant downstairs. She didn't go up, but directly sent Xu Qingzhu a message: [I'm downstairs, call me when you're done.]

Xu Qingzhu replied instantly: [We're done.]

Not long after, a group of people came out in a grand procession.

Sally had drunk quite a lot and could barely walk steadily, clinging to Lin Luoxi like a little puppy.

Lin Luoxi looked like she hadn't drunk much and was still relatively sober.

Xu Qingzhu had her suit jacket draped over her arm, aloof and dignified. Liang Shi got out of the car with an umbrella, and as soon as she looked up, her eyes met Xu Qingzhu's across the rain-filled sky.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly curved her lips, her eyes full of smiles.

She raised her arm and waved in Liang Shi's direction.

Liang Shi said: "Stand there and don't move."

Xu Qingzhu nodded and obediently replied: "Okay."

Liang Shi walked over with the umbrella.

Watching this, Sally's alcohol suddenly sobered up halfway, "Why does it feel like they're filming an idol drama¹? OMG."

Lin Luoxi said disdainfully: "Look at your unsophisticated appearance."

Zhou Yi'an, who had just come out, was standing at the entrance trying to light a cigarette. The rain was heavy and the wind was strong.

She tried several times, but the weak flame kept being blown out by the wind.

Hearing Sally's words, she looked up and saw Liang Shi holding the umbrella.

Memory suddenly pulled back to that summer.

That day's rain was heavier than this. She had no friends and stood alone in a small alley trying to light a cigarette.

Just like today.

Before long, someone came over, also holding a black umbrella, and brushed past her.

That face was very beautiful, beautiful to the point of being unforgettable at first sight.

But what attracted Zhou Yi'an wasn't that face.

It was the hostility and restless agitation in those eyes.

It was the feeling of scoundrels finding their own kind.

It was the magnetic attraction between bad kids.

She looked at that person's back with interest, then smiled with curved lips.

The other person turned back, looking at her with those eyes full of hostility, "What the hell are you laughing at?"

She laughed even louder, "Laughing at you, sister."

The other person looked over contemptuously, "Crazy."

Unlike all the other looks of disgust and fear that people gave her, when she looked at Zhou Yi'an, there was also intense interest.

It's just that all that interest was hidden beneath the hostility.

"Put on your jacket." That voice overlapping with the past rang out, but it no longer had the arrogance and hostility of before, only gentleness remained, like a cup of plain boiled water.

Zhou Yi'an pressed the lighter again, and the flame briefly lit up, but was blown out by the wind before it could light the cigarette.

In the distance, Liang Shi put away the umbrella and helped Xu Qingzhu put on her jacket, truly being considerate in every way.

Zhou Yi'an suddenly threw the lighter in her hand toward them.

With a loud snap, it was extremely loud.

Everyone looked over.

Liang Shi frowned with an impatient expression, but those eyes no longer had what she had once seen and been crazy about—badness.

How had it changed?

Zhou Yi'an sneered coldly.

She was wearing a gray hoodie and couldn't be bothered to look anymore. She put the hood up, revealing a slightly mischievous smile, then turned and walked away with large strides.

Sally, who had been startled, belatedly cursed: "Fuck!"

"Is she crazy?" Liang Shi bent down to pick up that discarded lighter and throw it in the trash, then changed her tone to ask Sally: "How are you getting back? Should I give you a ride?"

Lin Luoxi said: "I didn't drive. I'll take this drunk, you just take Zhu Zi² home."

"Okay, be careful on the road." Liang Shi instructed.

After parting with Sally and the others, Liang Shi also carefully instructed the employees who had come to the dinner together, watching them all take taxis home before taking Xu Qingzhu to the car.

Xu Qingzhu had been silently observing her behavior. Only after she hailed a car to send the last Omega employee who had been drinking safely away did she speak up: "Liang Shi, aren't you tired?"

Liang Shi: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu's voice was light and airy, as if it could scatter in the wind at any moment, "Being so considerate in every way, doing so many things to please me, taking care of everyone—aren't you tired?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Actually, she was a little tired.

But Liang Shi felt that she wasn't doing these things to please Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu's understanding had a misunderstanding.

She paused and replied gently: "I'm okay. Ensuring everyone's safety after a dinner party is very important."

Xu Qingzhu quietly listened to her speak.

"I'm not being considerate in every way to please you, I'm just doing what I should do." Liang Shi said: "You're drunk, it's a rainy day, I just finished sending my colleague's child home, then came to pick you up. This isn't pleasing you."

Liang Shi paused and suddenly laughed lightly, "Xu Qingzhu, if this counts, then you're too easily pleased. These are all small matters."

Liang Shi didn't take these things to heart; to her they were just simple acts.

Just like sending Xu Qingzhu's colleagues home—for her it was just a few words, but it could potentially save a life.

Xu Qingzhu was shocked by her phrase "these are all small matters."

Because she had always believed that character was revealed in the details.

And she didn't quite trust Liang Shi's character.

A person might be able to act—act kind, smart, act so convincingly it seemed real, but just like a crime scene would always leave traces of the criminal.

Fake would always be fake, and acting would definitely be exposed one day.

But Liang Shi's actions today had somehow touched the soft spot in her heart.

After getting in the car, she saw Ling Dang.

Ling Dang politely greeted her, "Hello, Aunt."

"Hello there." Xu Qingzhu greeted her back.

After that, Ling Dang became absorbed in watching cartoons and didn't talk anymore.

Xu Qingzhu's mind was also in chaos. She was thinking—could a person really change completely?

This question had appeared in her mind countless times, but had also been denied by her countless times.

But tonight, she wavered.

Footnotes:

¹ **wuwuwu**: An onomatopoeia representing crying sounds, commonly used in Chinese internet slang to express being emotionally moved or overwhelmed.

² **Zhu Zi**: An affectionate nickname for Xu Qingzhu. "Zhu" (竹) means bamboo, and "zi" (子) is a diminutive suffix, so it's like calling her "Little Bamboo."

³ **CP-shipping**: "CP" stands for "couple pairing" and refers to fans romantically pairing up characters or real people. This is a very popular activity in Chinese fandom culture.

⁴ **White-lotus-turned-dark**: A character archetype in Chinese web novels. "White lotus" (白蓮花) refers to someone who appears pure and innocent on the surface, while "turned dark" (黑化) means they reveal their true manipulative or villainous nature.

⁵ **Little animal in a melon field**: This is a reference to a famous line from Lu Xun's story "My Old Home" about a creature called "獾" (cha) that steals melons. Here it's used metaphorically to describe someone following gossip trails.